

Word family: **thing / things**

Base word: thing

Plural: things

Part of speech: noun (名詞)

Your sentence:

> “Listening to him is a bit like opening a window in a stuffy room, because suddenly ordinary **things** feel fresh again.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **things** is deliberately broad. It means the **ordinary objects, situations, experiences, activities, and small parts of everyday life around us**.

The speaker is not referring only to physical objects. Mr. Wong makes familiar parts of everyday life seem interesting and fresh again.

繁體中文： ** 日常生活中周圍各種普通的事物、情況、經歷或小事的概括稱呼**

中文翻譯：

> “...suddenly ordinary **things** feel fresh again.”

「.....本來平凡的**事物 / 日常種種**一下子都變得新鮮起來。」

Here:

ordinary things = 日常生活中各種平凡的人事物、情況和經歷

This is a good example of why **thing** should not simply be translated mechanically as 「東西」 every time.

1. **thing = physical object (實體物件) — 東西 ; 物件**

This is the most concrete meaning.

Meaning: A physical object whose exact name is unknown, unimportant, or not specified.

Practice 1

> “What is that **thing** on the table?”

「桌上那個**東西 / 物件**是甚麼？」

Practice 2

> “There were several strange **things** inside the box.”

「箱子裡有幾件奇怪的**東西**。」

****thing** = 沒有特別指出名稱，或名稱並不重要的一件實體物件**

This is the ordinary:

> ****thing = object****

sense.

2. ****thing** = matter/event/situation (事情 / 事件 / 情況) — 事情 ; 事**

This is one of the most important abstract meanings.

****Meaning:**** Something that happens, is discussed, needs attention, or forms part of a situation.

Practice 3

> “A strange ****thing**** happened on my way home.”

「我回家途中發生了一件奇怪的****事情****。」

Practice 4

> “There are several ****things**** we need to discuss.”

「我們有幾件****事情****需要討論。」

****thing** = 發生、需要處理、需要討論或值得注意的一件事情 / 事項**

Compare:

> “Pick up that thing.”

= 拿起那件****物件****。

> “We need to discuss one thing.”

= 我們需要討論一件**事情**。

These clearly require different learner interpretations.

3. **thing = idea/action/activity/type of behaviour (想法 / 做法 / 活動) — 事情 ; 做法 ; 活動**

Thing can refer broadly to an action, activity, habit, choice, or idea.

Practice 5

> “Travelling alone is not really my **thing**.”

「獨自旅行不是我真正喜歡或擅長的**活動 / 那一套**。」

Practice 6

> “The important **thing** is to stay calm.”

「最重要的**事情 / 做法**是保持冷靜。」

thing = 某個行動、活動、想法、做法或生活方式，而不是具體物件

This overlaps somewhat with Meaning 2, but it is useful to show because English **thing** is commonly used where Chinese would not naturally say 「東西」.

4. **things = circumstances / general situation (整體情況) — 情況 ; 近況 ; 局勢**

In the plural, **things** very often means the general state of affairs.

Practice 7

> “How are **things** at work?”

「你工作那邊最近**情況怎樣**？」

Practice 8

> “**Things** have improved since last month.”

「自上個月以來，**情況**已經有所改善。」

things = 某個人、地方或情境目前的整體情況和發展

This is not:

> several separate physical objects.

It is a broad plural meaning:

> **things = circumstances / situation**

5. **things = belongings / possessions (個人物品) — 東西 ; 隨身物品 ; belongings**

The plural **things** can also mean someone's personal possessions.

Practice 9

> “I packed my **things** and left.”

「我收拾好自己的**東西 / 行李物品**後便離開了。」

Practice 10

> “Please take all your **things** with you.”

「請把你的所有**個人物品**帶走。」

someone's things = 某人擁有、攜帶或使用的個人物品和財物

This is more specific than the general “physical object” sense because **my/your things** commonly means:

> **my/your belongings**

6. **thing = living creature/person treated vaguely (人 / 生物) — 小傢伙 ; 可憐的人 / 生物**

Thing can sometimes refer to a person or animal, especially when expressing sympathy, affection, criticism, or another emotional reaction.

Practice 11

> “The poor **thing** looked completely exhausted.”

「那個**可憐的小傢伙 / 可憐的人**看起來筋疲力盡。」

Practice 12

> “You clever little **thing**!”

「你這個聰明的**小傢伙**！」

thing = 帶有感情色彩地把某個人或生物稱為「傢伙 / 小東西」，語氣視上下文而定

This is informal and strongly context-dependent.

It should not be learners' default way of referring to people.

7. **thing** = subject/area someone likes or is good at (興趣 / 擅長領域) — 喜歡的事；擅長的東西

A very common conversational construction is:

> **something is my thing**

Practice 13

> “Cooking has always been my **thing**.”

「烹飪一直都是我很喜歡 / 很擅長的**事情**。」

Practice 14

> “Large parties aren't really my **thing**.”

「大型派對真的不是我喜歡的**那一套 / 活動**。」

be someone's thing = 是某人特別喜歡、感興趣、熟悉或擅長的活動 / 風格 / 領域

This is an informal lexicalized use and worth teaching explicitly.

8. **have a thing for** + person/type of thing (特別喜愛) — 對.....特別有好感 / 偏愛

Another common fixed expression:

Practice 15

> “She has a **thing for** old cameras.”

「她對舊相機**特別有興趣 / 偏愛**。」

Practice 16

> “He seems to have a **thing for** jazz musicians.”

「他似乎對爵士樂手**特別有好感**。」

have a thing for someone/something = 對某人或某類事物有特別強烈的喜愛、興趣或吸引

This is best treated as a fixed expression rather than another independent core meaning of bare **thing**.

Fixed expression: **the thing is... — 問題是 / 其實是.....**

This is extremely common in conversation.

Practice 17

> “The **thing is**, I don’t have enough time.”

「**問題是 / 其實是**，我沒有足夠時間。」

Practice 18

> “The **thing is**, nobody told me the plan had changed.”

「**問題在於**，沒有人告訴我計劃已經改了。」

the thing is... = 用來引出真正的問題、重要事實、理由或解釋

Here, **thing** does not mean a physical object.

Fixed expression: **do your own thing — 按自己的方式做；做自己喜歡的事**

Practice 19

> “Everyone was free to **do their own thing**.”

「每個人都可以**按自己的方式做自己想做的事**。」

Practice 20

> “He left the company because he wanted to **do his own thing**.”

「他離開公司，因為他想**按自己的想法發展 / 做自己想做的事**。」

do your own thing = 不跟隨別人的安排，按自己的興趣、風格或方法行事

This is an idiomatic extension.

Fixed expression: **one thing after another** — 一件接一件

Practice 21

> “It was **one thing after another** all morning.”

「整個早上都是**事情一件接一件地發生**。」

Practice 22

> “First the train was late, then I lost my keys—it was **one thing after another**.”

「先是火車延誤，然後又丟了鎖匙，真是**麻煩事一件接一件**。」

This uses the general **event/matter** sense.

Fixed expression: **a thing of the past** — 已成過去的事物

Practice 23

> “Paper tickets may soon become a **thing of the past**.”

「紙製車票可能很快會**成為歷史 / 成為過去的事物**。」

Practice 24

> “For many people, handwritten letters are already a **thing of the past**.”

「對很多人來說，手寫信件已經是**過去的事物**。」

a thing of the past = 曾經常見或存在，但現在已消失或逐漸被淘汰的事物 / 做法

Important distinction: **thing** vs **object**

object

usually means a physical, identifiable item.

> “There were several objects on the desk.”

thing

is much broader.

It can mean:

- * an object
- * an event
- * a situation
- * an idea
- * an activity
- * belongings
- * general circumstances

Therefore:

object = mainly physical entity

thing = extremely broad placeholder noun

This is why translating every **thing** as 「東西」 often produces unnatural Chinese.

Important distinction: **thing** vs **stuff**

thing

is normally countable:

- > one thing
- > three things

stuff

is normally uncountable:

> some stuff

> a lot of stuff

Not normally:

> three stuffs ❌

Both can be vague, but:

> “my things”

= 我的多件個人物品

> “my stuff”

= 我的東西 / 物品，視為一個整體

Important distinction: **thing** vs **matter**

thing

is very broad and conversational.

> “There’s one thing we need to discuss.”

matter

often means an issue, subject, or situation requiring consideration.

> “This is a serious matter.”

So **matter** cannot replace **thing** in all its physical and everyday uses.

Important distinction: **thing** vs **situation**

situation

specifically refers to a set of circumstances.

thing

can refer much more broadly to almost any entity, matter, activity, or event.

> “Things are improving.”

can mean:

> “The situation is improving.”

But:

> “Pass me that thing.”

cannot mean:

> “Pass me that situation.”

Family-extension note

Unlike many vocabulary targets, **thing** has almost no productive derivational family.

Its learning richness comes from:

- * extremely broad reference;
- * singular vs plural patterns;
- * abstract vs physical senses;
- * fixed conversational expressions.

Useful constructions include:

- * a thing
- * things
- * my/your things
- * the thing is...
- * my thing
- * have a thing for
- * do your own thing
- * one thing after another
- * a thing of the past

The Golden Manual says a small morphological family should remain small rather than being padded with artificial derivatives.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
thing — physical object	名稱未知、不重要或沒有特別指出的一件實體物件
thing — matter/event	發生、需要處理、需要討論或值得注意的一件事情 / 事項
-----	-----
thing — activity/idea/action	某個活動、做法、選擇、想法或行為的概括稱呼
things — circumstances	某個人、地方或情境目前的整體情況、近況或發展
someone's things — belongings	某人擁有、攜帶或使用的個人物品和財物
thing — person/creature, informal	帶有同情、親暱、批評等感情色彩地稱呼某人或生物為「傢伙 / 小東西」
-----	-----
be someone's thing	是某人特別喜歡、感興趣或擅長的活動、風格或領域
have a thing for	對某人或某類事物有特別強烈的喜愛、興趣或吸引
the thing is...	用來引出真正的問題、重要事實、理由或解釋
do your own thing	按自己的興趣、風格或方法做自己想做的事

For your original sentence

> "...suddenly ordinary **things** feel fresh again."

The exact meaning is:

things = 日常生活中各種普通的事物、情況、活動、經歷和小事情的概括稱呼

It is deliberately broader than:

> **physical objects**

So:

> **ordinary things feel fresh again**

= **平日那些普通而熟悉的日常種種，又重新令人覺得新鮮有趣**

For your database, I would count **6 genuinely useful core meanings** for **thing**:

1. **physical object**
2. **matter/event/situation to discuss or deal with**
3. **activity/action/idea/type of behaviour**
4. **things — general circumstances/state of affairs**
5. **someone's things — belongings/possessions**
6. **informal — person or creature referred to vaguely/emotionally**

Then I would keep ****my thing****, ****have a thing for****, ****the thing is****, and ****do your own thing**** as important fixed/conversational extensions rather than inflate the core count.